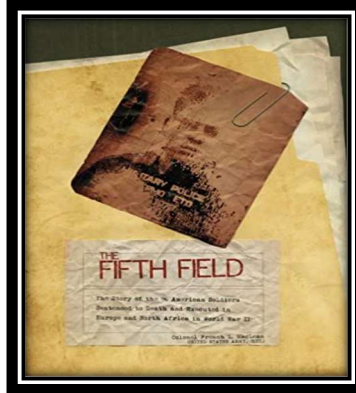


THE FIFTH FIELD AKA PLOT "E"

THE STORY (AND THE GRAVESITES) OF THE 96 AMERICAN SOLDIERS SENTENCED TO DEATH AND EXECUTED IN EUROPE AND NORTH AFRICA IN WW2

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The Fifth Field: reveals one of the final secrets of the war, how 96 American soldiers in Europe and North Africa were tried by American General Courts-Martial, convicted by military juries, sentenced to death, executed, and buried in an obscure, secret plot at an American military cemetery in France. Their case files remained in a dark closet until after Nine-Eleven, almost like the Ark of the Covenant at the end of *Raiders of the Lost Ark*. Eat your heart out Harrison Ford; this was the real mystery solved. "A 'Rosetta Stone' for every future historian researching and writing about Army courts-martial in World War II," says the Judge Advocate General Center and School Historian.

A non-fiction book, but you will swear you are reading a mystery fiction thriller. It begins with a visit to the cemetery, where to this day – seven decades after the war – their small flat gravestones bear only the numbers 1-96, not names, chiseled into them.

These were not crimes against enemy soldiers or against civilians actively supporting the enemy. These 96 soldiers murdered 26 fellow American military personnel, and killed or raped 71 British, French, Irish, Italian, Polish, and Algerian civilians, in addition to the one soldier executed exclusively for desertion.

The executions were not ad hoc, shot-while-trying-to-escape killings. Every single verdict had been personally approved by General Dwight D. Eisenhower or another high-ranking Theater Commander.

Many of the executions occurred in the French villages, where previously the crime had occurred. There were no last-minute opportunities to avoid the noose by volunteering for a suicidal mission à la the fictional account of condemned soldiers in *The Dirty Dozen*, although one American general, as discussed in the book, really did propose something similar.

The actual cases are the stars of the book. The public only knows of one – Eddie Slovik – and knows little of the process involved. The courts-martial, some of which started just five days after the commission of the crime, were to the point and strict ("if the glove won't fit, you must acquit" tactics were not allowed); some proceedings took as little as one hour. Judge Advocate reviews then took a few weeks, although the defendant had no legal representation, nor did he appear at these later proceedings.

Unnamed Graves, a Secret Cemetery, Files Closed to the Public and Stored in "The Vault." During World War II, in the North African/Mediterranean and European Theaters of Operation, 96 American soldiers were convicted by Army General Courts-Martial and executed for desertion, murder and rape.

Their victims were 26 fellow American soldiers and 71 British, French, Italian, Polish and Algerian civilians. The executions were not ad hoc killings. General Eisenhower, or another theater commander, approved every proceeding, but the Army did not trumpet the crimes. **After the war, the Army searched for a suitable site to enter the remains of all 96 men.** It chose a plot of land adjacent to – but technically outside of – the World War I American cemetery of Oise-Aisne. **The area is separated from the main cemetery by a high stone wall, concealed from view, and is closed to casual visitors. Called "Plot E" by the staff, others refer to it as "The Fifth Field."** The judicial files on the 96 were even harder to find – until now.



Oise-Aisne American Cemetery and Memorial (Photo by Victor Grigas/Wikimedia Commons)

Surprisingly, the Army found that it had no qualified hangman, so English hangmen conducted 16 executions for crimes committed in Britain, but British hangmen could not serve outside England. Matters became so serious that Eisenhower ordered a U. S. Army brigadier general to hang four condemned soldiers one chilly morning in Sicily in 1943. The Army finally found a hangman, with claimed experience in Texas and Oklahoma. That was untrue – he had no previous practice, but the Army remained unaware of his deception and promoted him from private to master sergeant in a single day, but he botched at least one-third of the hangings he conducted. **Seven of the 96 condemned met their ends by firing squads.** Ricochets and bad marksmanship sometimes marred the proceedings.

The Army did its level best to ensure the trials were fair, although a review of the wartime legal system led to significant changes after the conflict. After spending a decade poring over the files – in the author's opinion – three of the soldiers likely were not guilty, ten others were possibly not guilty, while two dozen others could have received life imprisonment and not the death penalty, because of mitigating circumstances.

In the final research, the author obtained the use of several original photographs of four of the actual executions (two hangings and two firing squads), from the possession of one of the officers at the events in 1945 at the Aversa, Italy Stockade. Photographs of this nature and significance have not been published since the execution of the Lincoln Conspirators in 1865!

Since the book was published, several veterans and family members have contacted the author. One of the murder weapons has now been located and other important information obtained. If you or a family member have any letters, diaries, or old photographs related to this story, please contact the author through the contact page.

PLOT "E"

A visit to Plot E – the final resting place of the dishonored dead.

February 15, 2017

I have visited many American military cemeteries over the years, and I have always found them to be beautiful and humbling places. They are quiet and dignified Edens wherein lie the honored dead who have defended the nation.

There is one cemetery, though, that doesn't quite live up to this archetype.

Officially Plot E does not exist. Go ahead and look. You won't find it listed on the Veterans Administration website, nor any of the literature provided by the cemetery. Maps will show Plots A, B, C, and D only, those containing 6012 American dead from WWI. Google Earth will just show an expanse of green. It's like it doesn't exist, which is exactly what its creators intended.

But it's very much there and serves a necessary if somewhat unsavory purpose.

Plot E is where American servicemen are buried who were executed – by firing squad or hanging – for capital crimes committed in the European theatre during or shortly after WWII. Some of the victims were children. Many were women. Most are forgotten by the modern age, though at least one – Sir Eric Teichman, killed on his ancestral estate confronting two U.S. soldiers poaching on the land – was a prominent member of society who still has his own Wikipedia page.

Those capital crimes once included aggravated rape, murder, and desertion, though currently none interred in Plot E are deserters. More on that in a moment.

Plot E of the Oise-Aisne American cemetery in northern France:



Plot E is located 100 meters from the main cemetery and contains the remains of 94 servicemen. It is across a small road and deliberately hidden from view by a tall border of hedgerows that surrounds the 90' x 50' oval space. Because of the dense shrubbery, and the fact that there is no path nor gate, the only access to the area is **through the back door of the cemetery superintendent's office... and this is highly discouraged.**

There are no gravestones, nor any plaques with names – the graves are designated by white index-card-sized stone markers with stark black numbers, in four rows, and all facing away from the recognized burial ground nearby. Plot E has been described by one cemetery employee as a “house of shame” and “the perfect anti-memorial,” as the original intent was that none of the individual remains were ever to be identifiable by name (it was only after a Freedom of Information lawsuit in 2009 that a list of grave numbers and occupants was released to the public). **No U.S. flag is allowed to fly there**, although there is a single small granite cross on one side. Nevertheless, it is maintained, with grass being cut and hedges trimmed, perhaps more for the aesthetic sensibilities of the superintendent than due to any niceties afforded the deceased.

Originally, the 98 condemned by the U.S. Army following general courts-martial were buried near the sites of their executions, which took place at locations as far-flung as England, France, Belgium, Germany, Italy, and Algeria. In 1949, however, it was decided to relocate all such remains to a single venue; that

site is described by the Graves Registration as being for “the dishonored dead,” since, according to protocol, all had been dishonorably discharged from the service just before execution.



For reasons unclear, two of those executed during the 1940s never were sent to Plot E. Two others were buried there but later exhumed and returned to the United States. One of those was Private Alex F. Miranda, who came back to the U.S. in 1990, though details of the transfer were never made public.

The second was the former occupant of Row 3, #65, Private Eddie Slovik, the only man executed during WWII for desertion. His later became a cause celebre, as other soldiers deserted during the war, but Eisenhower decided to make a sole example of the rough street kid from Detroit on 31 January 1945. His remains were finally returned to the U.S. on the order of President Reagan in 1987, and rest today at Woodmere Cemetery in the city of his birth, next to the grave of his wife.

REMARKS: Plot E is maintained and controlled by the American Battle Monuments Commission as are all US Military Cemetery's throughout the world. They have received many requests from agencies such as CBS and members of Congress, on behalf of voters to visit Plot E, for various reasons. They have done their best to discourage visitations also for various and questionable reasons. There are many letters concerning this subject as well as those concerning the body of Eddie Slovik, a deserter whose body was exhumed and returned to the United States. *If you want to know about Plot E click on the below link and read copies of the many letters concerning the subject.*

https://www.governmentattic.org/46docs/ABMCoiseAisneAmerCemetery_1971-2019.pdf

Directly below is a letter from the file referenced above from the American Battle Monuments Commission (ABMC) dated March 7, 2019, *outlining their visitation policy concerning Plot E.*

POLICY NUMBER: 7 .28 March 7, 2019
American Battle Monuments Commission Policy
Cemetery Operations Manual
Plot It Visitation
Effective Date: 03-07-2019 Sunset Date: 03-07-2022

1. PURPOSE

This document sets forth the American Battle Monuments Commission (ABMC) policy concerning visitation to "Plot E", a burial ground for executed World War II servicemen, located on the grounds of Oise-Aisne American Cemetery, France.

2. BACKGROUND

Visitation requests for Plot E have increased over the years, especially since the publication of books such as *The Fifth Field* and *The Interpreter*. There is also a diverse assortment of less factual online publications that feed a false narrative of a clandestine burial area that is not "officially" recognized by the U.S. government.

Some of these publications are critical of the U.S. Military, specifically regarding the treatment of African-American soldiers during the Second World War.

As a result of this increased awareness, Plot E has the potential to become a sensitive topic for the American Battle Monuments Commission. Approximately 75-80% of these burials are African-American, although African-Americans only made up approximately 10% of the U.S. Armed Forces in World War II.

Nonetheless, the origin and existence of Plot E is part of American military history, so its existence should not be denied or hidden.

3. POLICY

Visitation requests, primarily via walk-ins, have not been managed consistently by assigned superintendents. To have a more consistent approach, the following policy and administrative guidance are provided to facilitate the processing of visitation requests. The U.S. government recognizes Plot E as an official American military burial ground. However, because the mission of the American Battle Monument Commission is to commemorate those who served and sacrificed honorably in the U.S. armed forces, *the existence of Plot E will not be advertised or promoted on the ABMC website, in social media, or in our pamphlets.* However, Superintendents may at their discretion incorporate the story of Plot E into their interpretation program.

Issue Date: 03-07-2018 1 Plot E Visitation

DISCLAIMER

PLEASE UNDERSTAND THAT EVEN THOUGH THIS INFORMATION HAS BEEN TAKEN FROM WEBSITES & OTHER SOURCES THAT APPEAR TO BE AUTHENTIC, I CAN NOT ENSURE THAT ALL THE DATA IN THIS ARTICLE IS ACCURATE AND CORRECT.